JP

FIRST-TIME JAPAN TRAVEL

JAPAN LIKE A LOCAL

A practical pocket guide to money, trains, manners, phrases and the small things that make Japan easier.

MADE FOR FIRST-TIME VISITORS

Read this once before landing, then keep the final cheat sheet on your phone.

SEPTEMBER 2026 EDITION | UPDATED OCTOBER 2026

Before You Land

Japan is easy to travel once you know a few unwritten rules. This guide focuses on the details that often surprise first-time visitors.

Your 10-minute setup

- Keep some Japanese yen in cash. Cards are common, but cash is still useful.
- Set up or buy a rechargeable IC transit card if it works for your route and device.
- Save your hotel name and address in both English and Japanese.
- Download an offline map area and a translation app.
- Carry a small bag for trash; public bins can be limited.
- Save emergency numbers: Police 110 / Fire & Ambulance 119.

LOCAL MINDSET

When unsure, watch what people around you are doing. In Japan, consideration for other people is the safest default.

The five things most visitors should remember

1. Tipping is generally not expected.
2. Cash still matters.
3. Trash bins may be hard to find.
4. Trains are quiet spaces.
5. “Sumimasen” is one of the most useful words you can learn.

Money Without Stress

Japan is much more cashless than it used to be, especially in major cities. Still, some smaller shops, rural businesses, ticket machines and local services may require cash.

A simple payment strategy

Card: Use it where accepted for hotels, larger shops and many restaurants.

Cash: Keep a backup amount for small businesses, rural areas and places that do not accept your card.

IC card: A prepaid transit card such as Suica, PASMO or ICOCA can make trains easier and can also be used at many vending machines, convenience stores and other locations.

DON'T PANIC AT THE REGISTER

Look for card or IC logos near the register. If you are unsure, show your card and ask: “Kaado, daijobu desu ka?” (Is card okay?)

Useful money phrase

Ikura desu ka?
How much is it?

Trains Like a Local

Japan's rail system is extensive, but large stations can feel overwhelming. Focus on the line name, direction, platform and final destination shown on signs.

The easy version

- Use an IC card for ordinary local travel where accepted: tap in, tap out.
- Queue at the floor markings before the train arrives.
- Let passengers exit before you board.
- Keep phone calls off local trains and keep your voice low.
- Move backpacks off your back on crowded trains.
- Eating is fine on many long-distance trains such as Shinkansen, but is generally avoided on local/subway trains.

MISSED YOUR STOP?

Stay calm. Get off at the next station and use your map, or ask station staff. Staffed gates are your friend when a ticket or IC card does not work.

Station phrase

___ wa doko desu ka?
Where is ___?

Small Manners, Big Difference

You do not need to memorize hundreds of rules. A few habits will cover most situations.

No tipping by default

Tipping is generally not expected in restaurants, taxis and hotels. Pay the amount shown unless a specific service clearly says otherwise.

Shoes

Remove shoes when entering homes, many traditional accommodations, and some restaurants or temples. A raised entrance, shoe rack or slippers may indicate a shoes-off area. Check signs or ask staff before entering.

Queues

People line up for trains, restaurants and shops. Follow floor markings and join the end of the line.

Trash

Public trash bins can be limited. Carry a small bag and dispose of trash when you find an appropriate bin.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Try not to inconvenience the people around you. That one idea explains a lot of everyday etiquette in Japan.

Convenience Stores Are Your Friend

Japanese convenience stores — often called **konbini** — are useful travel bases, not just snack shops.

What they are useful for

- Quick meals, drinks, snacks and basic toiletries.
- ATMs at many locations; international card support varies by ATM/network.
- Paying with cash, card or IC/e-money depending on the store and terminal.
- A reliable place to regroup, buy water and solve small travel problems.

EASY FIRST MEAL

If ordering at a restaurant feels intimidating on day one, a konbini is a low-stress way to get familiar with Japanese food labels and prices.

Useful phrase

Kore, onegaishimasu.
This one, please.

Restaurants Without Anxiety

Many restaurants display photos, plastic food models, ticket machines or tablet menus. You can often order successfully with very little Japanese.

A simple routine

- At the entrance, wait to be seated unless the setup clearly shows self-seating.
- Use photos or point politely if language is difficult.
- If there is a ticket machine, buy the meal ticket first and hand it to staff.
- Do not leave a tip unless the service specifically operates differently.
- At busy places, avoid lingering long after finishing your meal.

ALLERGY NOTE

Do not rely only on translation apps for serious food allergies. Prepare a clearly written allergy card in Japanese before your trip and confirm with staff.

Menu phrase

Eigo no menyuu wa arimasu ka?
Do you have an English menu?

8 Phrases That Do Real Work

Sumimasen	Excuse me / Sorry / A polite way to get attention
Arigatou gozaimasu	Thank you very much
Onegaishimasu	Please / This, please
Kore, onegaishimasu	This one, please
___ wa doko desu ka?	Where is ___?
Toire wa doko desu ka?	Where is the restroom?
Ikura desu ka?	How much is it?
Daijoubu desu	I'm okay / No thank you / It's fine (depends on context)

IF YOU LEARN ONLY ONE

Learn “Sumimasen.” It can mean excuse me, sorry, or politely getting someone's attention — extremely useful for travelers.

Common First-Timer Mistakes

Mistake 1: Assuming everywhere takes cards.
Keep some cash as backup, especially outside major city centers.

Mistake 2: Talking loudly on trains.
Keep conversations quiet and avoid phone calls on local trains.

Mistake 3: Looking for a trash bin every five minutes.
Carry your trash until you find an appropriate place to dispose of it.

Mistake 4: Tipping automatically.
In most everyday situations, it is unnecessary.

Mistake 5: Trying to understand the whole station at once.
Only solve the next step: line, direction, platform, destination.

Mistake 6: Overplanning every minute.
Leave buffer time for large stations, wrong exits and spontaneous discoveries.

GOOD TRAVELER > PERFECT TRAVELER

You will make small mistakes. Be polite, stay observant, and ask for help. That is enough.

When You Need Help

Save these before your trip:

POLICE — 110

Use for urgent police emergencies.

FIRE / AMBULANCE — 119

Use for urgent fire or medical emergencies.

Japan Visitor Hotline

JNTO operates a visitor hotline 24 hours a day, 365 days a year, with support in English, Chinese and Korean. Save the current hotline details from the official Japan National Tourism Organization website before departure.

Lost something?

Ask station staff, the shop or hotel first. Lost property is often handled by the facility where it was found before being transferred elsewhere.

Medical needs

For serious symptoms, use emergency services. For non-emergency care, ask your hotel or official visitor support service for nearby options that can assist international travelers.

Your First 24 Hours

Use this as a low-stress landing plan.

At the airport

- Get connected: eSIM/SIM/Wi-Fi.
- Get cash if needed.
- Set up your IC card or confirm your train/bus ticket.

On the way to the hotel

- Follow the route one transfer at a time.
- Keep your hotel address ready in Japanese.

Near the hotel

- Find the nearest station entrance you will use tomorrow.
- Locate a convenience store and an ATM option.
- Buy water and a simple breakfast/snack.

Before sleeping

- Check tomorrow's weather and first train route.
- Charge phone and power bank.
- Put a small trash bag, cash and IC card in your day bag.

DAY ONE GOAL

Do not try to conquer Japan on arrival day. Learn your neighborhood, eat something good, and get some sleep.

One-Page Cheat Sheet

MONEY	Card + some cash + IC card.
TRAINS	Tap in/out. Queue. Let people exit. Keep quiet.
TIPPING	Usually no tip.
TRASH	Carry a small bag; bins may be limited.
SHOES	Remove if required. Check signs or ask staff.
HELP	Sumimasen = your all-purpose polite opener.
POLICE	110
FIRE / AMBULANCE	119

Three phrases to screenshot

Sumimasen. — Excuse me / Sorry
Kore, onegaishimasu. — This one, please.
Toire wa doko desu ka? — Where is the restroom?

SCREENSHOT THIS PAGE

Keep it in your Favorites album so you can reach it quickly when your signal is weak.

Official Sources & Updates

Travel rules, transport products and service details can change. Before departure, verify time-sensitive information with official sources.

Japan National Tourism Organization (JNTO) — Travel Japan

Used to verify guidance on tipping, cashless payments, IC travel cards, rail manners and emergency support for this September 2026 edition.

Recommended official pages to check before travel:

- Travel planning and etiquette
- IC travel cards
- Rail travel
- Cashless payments and credit cards
- Japan Visitor Hotline

IMPORTANT

This is a practical travel guide, not legal, immigration, medical or emergency advice. Visa, customs, tax-free shopping, transport and entry rules may change. Always verify current requirements with the relevant official authority.

JAPAN LIKE A LOCAL

Know more. Worry less. Enjoy Japan.